Their special shops, sojourns in the non-socialist world, private use of jets for holidays, remuneration in and ownership of hard currency, and, above all, the privileges granted to the children, grandchildren and relatives of members of the Politburo and government are the subjects of repeated and ubiquitous criticism.

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With tempers running ragged, Erich Honecker was placed under house arrest on 5 December, along with Günter Mittag and propaganda chief Joachim Herrmann – all three faced charges of abusing their posts for personal gain and were not allowed to leave Wandlitz. Mittag, for instance, was accused of personal enrichment by giving two state-funded luxury villas to his daughters, while trade union boss Harry Tisch – who was also detained – reportedly 'ran a hunting estate like a feudal baron'. Separate investigations were opened against Honecker's close associate Wolfgang Vogel, who was arrested on blackmail charges. (For years, Vogel had been used as a 'go-between' during delicate swaps of intelligence agents and other prisoners, including American U-2 spyplane pilot Gary Powers). The news spotlight briefly turned to Honecker's first daughter (with Edith Baumann), Erica Wildau-Honecker, then 39 and wife of the GDR ambassador to the Netherlands, Karl Wildau. Ambushed by paparazzi in The Hague, she declined to comment on her father's fate and gave a beaming smile when asked if her days in Holland were numbered.

On the sixth, more revelations of a huge network of corruption inside the SED forced Krenz to stand down as head of state, representing a further abdication of power by the SED to reformers. With the Socialist Unity Party utterly discredited, Manfred Gerlach, leader of the non-communist Liberal Democratic Party was appointed his successor and Gregor Gysi, a reformer, became the SED's new leader. In his first speech, Gysi acknowledged that the Party had brought the GDR to ruin. He repudiated everything it had done since 1949 and declared the SED needed to adopt a 'new form' of socialism.